

► Derenburg burning

The 1555 witch trial at Derenburg, Saxony, became one of Germany's most notorious, largely because of this widely disseminated print showing the public burning of three of the four condemned women.



GRUESOME PENALTIES

witch trials

From the 14th to the 18th centuries, around 50,000 people were executed for witchcraft in Europe and North America, some four-fifths of whom were women. The most extreme purges took place in the late 16th and early 17th centuries in Europe.

In his final years, 1436–1438, Johannes Nider, a professor of theology, wrote the *Formicarius*, the fifth book of which dealt with witchcraft. He wrote of “A great many witches of both sexes who greatly hated human nature and assumed the likenesses of

various kinds of beasts, especially those kinds that devour children,” going on to give anecdotal descriptions of child-slaying. This book was later published as part of the *Malleus Maleficarum* (“Hammer of Witches”) in 1486, which gave the courts a treatise that they could use to take a harder line in prosecuting witchcraft. As the Protestant Reformation swept through parts of Northern Europe from the 1540s, it gave customs that had until then been tolerated the taint of witchcraft, which further fueled the prosecutors’ zeal.



Patterns of persecution

A series of laws were passed against witchcraft from the second half of the 16th century, including Acts in England in 1562 and 1604, and there was a spate of witch trials. In western Germany, the zealous archbishop of Trier set out to purge his small territory of nonconformists, including witches, and he alone accounted for 300 executions in the 1580s and 1590s. Scotland executed at least

◄ Raising a storm against the king

This woodcut illustrates the 1590 witch trial in North Berwick, Scotland: Agnes Sampson confessed under torture to using magic to raise a storm to sink James VI’s ship as he sailed home with his bride, Anne of Denmark.